

mono-directional synchronisation job from one location to another.

First time backup

To create a backup for the first time, follow the steps given below:

Step 1: Open the tool by running *DirSyncPro.exe*

Step 2: Once the console opens, you'll notice that the tool has already created a sample job for you. You can either edit this job by clicking on the *Edit* button or remove this job by clicking on the *Remove* button, and then create a new one by clicking on the *New* button.

Step 3: Click on the *Edit* button. In the *Edit Job* window set the label for the job, set *Dir A* (the folder to back up) and *Dir B* (the folder where the backup should be stored; it can be a different partition, a USB drive or a network location) and set the *Sync Mode*. Since this is the first time, choose *Backup A -> B (full)*. This will ensure that all the files, folders and sub-folders in the selected directory are copied to the location specified in the *Dir B* field. Do not forget to check the *Include sub folders* check box. Please note that even though it's implied that this is 'Full Backup', it's actually a 'Mirror Backup'.



Note: Before proceeding with the next step, make sure that the directory in which the backup will be stored is empty, or the contents of the directory will be deleted automatically.

Step 4: Press *OK* and click the *Play* button.

Step 5: Once the backup is complete, click on the *Save Job Set* button, and save the current configuration.

To add more jobs to the job set, simply click *New* and *Configure* as explained in Step 3. Once all the jobs have been configured, click the *Play* button to execute.

Ongoing backups

Using the configuration file saved earlier, the task of daily backups becomes simple. All you need to do is open the configuration file and for each of the jobs, in the job set, modify the *Sync mode* to *Mirror A->B (incremental)* and then execute by clicking the *Play* button. As explained earlier, the *Mirror (incremental)* function copies only the new and modified files to the backup location.

Scheduling backups

DirSync Pro comes with a scheduling engine, which enables users to schedule jobs at various intervals (once, every minute, every hour, or daily, weekly, monthly, yearly, or even a custom option). Unfortunately, it does not allow you to schedule the entire job set at once, so each job has to be scheduled individually.

Follow these steps to schedule a job:

Step 1: Select a job and click on the *Edit* button.

Step 2: In the *Edit* window click on the *Schedule* tab.

Step 3: Click on *New* button.

Step 4: In the *Schedule Options* window, select the desired interval. Once an interval is selected, its corresponding tab gets enabled.

Step 5: Select the tab corresponding to the selected interval and configure the desired pattern.

Step 6: Press *OK* in the *Schedule Options* window. Press *OK* in the *Edit Job* window.

Restore

Creating a restore job is similar to creating the ongoing backup job. Open the configuration file and, for each of the jobs, modify the *Sync Mode* to *Restore B -> A (full)* for a full restore. Press *OK* and execute using the *Play* button. This will restore the entire data from the backup location to the original location.

DirSync Pro is a powerful tool and is a good alternative to high-end backup solutions. While users can get started with the tool using the above tutorial, more resources can be found at <http://www.dirsyncpro.org/>

FreeFileSync

FreeFileSync, developed by Zenju, is another free and open source file and folder synchronisation and comparison tool. It can work on multiple platforms and can be easily used as data backup software. The graphical user interface is easy to navigate and simple to learn.

Notable features

- Portable
- Platform-agnostic
- Bi-directional synchronisation
- File comparison based on time, size and content
- Easy to navigate user interface

Getting the tool

FreeFileSync is available for download at <http://www.foosshub.com/FreeFileSync.html>. The download page lists all the available variants. The current version, at the time of writing this article, is 6.3.

For the purposes of this article, we will use the Windows version, but feel free to download and install the one appropriate for your system.

Installing the tool

Once the file is downloaded, execute it and proceed with the installation.

Using the tool

FreeFileSync is similar to DirSync Pro. Since both are file and folder synchronisation tools, setting up a backup or restore job simply means creating a mono-directional synchronisation job from one hard drive to another.

First time backup

To backup files for the first time, please follow the steps below: